

## THE FOX

## Vulpecula



SIZE RANKING 55

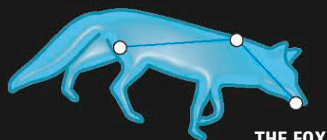
BRIGHTEST STAR  
Alpha ( $\alpha$ ) 4.4

GENITIVE Vulpeculae

ABBREVIATION Vul

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM  
August–SeptemberFULLY VISIBLE  
90°N–61°S

This small, faint northern constellation lies in the Milky Way, south of Cygnus. When it was first introduced in the late 17th century by the Polish astronomer Johannes Hevelius (see panel, below), it was



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named *Vulpecula cum Anser* (the fox with the goose). Its name has since been simplified to Vulpecula. Despite its relative obscurity, it contains two unmissable objects for binocular users.

## SPECIFIC FEATURES

The brightest star in the constellation, Alpha ( $\alpha$ ) Vulpeculae, is a 4th-magnitude red giant with a 6th-magnitude orange star nearby, which is visible with binoculars. The two lie at different distances and are unrelated.

Brocchi's Cluster is one of the binocular treasures of the sky. This grouping of 10 stars, with components ranging from 5th to 7th magnitude, is better known as the Coathanger because of its shape: a line of six stars forms the bar of the hanger, while the remaining four are

the hook. All the stars are unrelated, however, and so do not form a true cluster. The Coathanger's shape is therefore the delightful product of a chance alignment.

Popularly known as the Dumbbell Nebula, M27 is the easiest planetary nebula to spot in the sky. It appears as a rounded patch, about one-third the

size of a full moon, when viewed through binoculars. Its twin-lobed or hourglass shape is revealed only with larger instruments and on long-exposure photographs. It is about 1,000 light-years away. CCD images and photographs show a variety of colors, but visually the Dumbbell appears gray-green.

## THE COATHANGER ♠

Perhaps the most charming of all star clusters is Brocchi's Cluster, also known as the Coathanger. This group of stars, easily visible through binoculars, appears to mark out the shape of a simple coathanger.

## THE DUMBBELL NEBULA ♠♠♠

Reputedly the easiest planetary nebula to spot, M27 can be found with binoculars on dark nights. A telescope is needed to make out the twin lobes that give rise to its popular name.



## JOHANNES HEVELIUS

Johannes Hevelius (1611–1687) was born and worked in the town of Danzig, Germany (now Gdansk, Poland), where he established an observatory equipped with the finest instruments of his time. Among his legacies was a star catalog and atlas, published posthumously by his assistant and second wife, Elizabeth, introducing seven new constellations and filling the gaps in the northern skies.



## JOINT EFFORT

Johannes Hevelius and his wife Elizabeth measured star positions with a large sextant. This instrument is commemorated in one of the constellations Hevelius invented, Sextans.

## FOX IN THE MILKY WAY

Vulpecula is a shapeless constellation sandwiched between the more easily recognizable pattern of Sagitta, the arrow (at the left of this picture), and the head of the swan, Cygnus.